

31, Explanations Regarding Certain Personal Judgments

I will conclude by explaining some of my personal judgments; I leave it to the readers to independently discern the ultimate rationality of these judgments.

Why do I perpetually and vehemently oppose the formulation of "national characteristics" (民族性)? The reason is that, as a student of science and engineering, I must assert that it is far too unfalsifiable, making it exceedingly difficult to believe this constitutes science. If we label every distinct trait of every ethnicity in the world relative to others as "national characteristics," then what have we ultimately researched? Is this not equivalent to spouting a pile of useless tautologies? Whenever possible, one ought to devise methods to rigorously research the local historical trajectory of the society in question, rather than attempting to gloss over matters using utterly undefinable concepts. Not only will such concepts cause misdirection in research, but they will identically exacerbate the mutual prejudices among humanity.

Why do I maintain that Confucianism (儒家学说) is not a religion? My reasoning is exceedingly simple: the history of China is frequently far too exceptional, to the extent that it is phenomenally difficult to correlate Confucianism with any specific typology of religion.

First, if readers have followed the sequence up to this point, they can inevitably discern at a glance that Confucianism during the **restoration-bureaucratic period** (复辟官僚时期) fundamentally cannot be termed a religion. It was, naturally, no longer a **classical religion** (古典宗教), but it was even less possible for it to be a **feudal religion** (封建宗教). Factually speaking, one of the paramount characteristics of a **restoration-bureaucratic state** (复辟官僚国家) is its anti-religious nature; the imperial court spared no effort in emasculating the status of religion within social life.

Second, we might perhaps argue that the scholasticism (经学) during the Han Dynasty (两汉时期) constituted a **classical religion**, as it indeed possessed certain characteristics of **classical religions**. But what **classical religion** monopolized absolute dominance to support the entire classical bureaucratic system (古典官僚体制)? I contend that the most colossal disparity between Han Dynasty Confucianism and **classical religions** lies in the fact that the core objective of a **classical religion** is to support monarchical despotism (君主专制), whereas the core objective of Han Confucianism was to support the bureaucratic system (官僚制度). The ideological role of supporting monarchical despotism during the Han Dynasty largely belonged to mysticism, such as Yin-Yang and the Five Elements (阴阳五行). Although Confucianism merged with mysticism either actively (*Confucian scholars proactively embracing it*) or passively (*the imperial court forcibly propelling it*), there ultimately remained a massive distinction. Under these circumstances, categorizing Han Confucianism as a **classical religion** lacks taxonomic necessity.

Furthermore, during the 3rd to 6th centuries, the period when China's **feudalization** (封建化) was most conspicuous, the participation of Confucianism in social ideology (社会意识形态) was highly limited; the religious ecological niche (生态位) clearly belonged to the foreign-introduced Buddhism. Conversely, pre-Han Confucianism was ostensibly much like early Buddhism: far more akin to an academic school holding specific philosophical standpoints than any sort of religion.

Since Confucianism across these four distinct periods all exhibited disparities with religion, there is fundamentally zero rationale to consider it a religion. However, many Chinese people, myself included, occasionally adopt the terminology of "Confucian religion" (儒教) when discussing

Confucianism. Yet, this is actually an emotional sarcasm directed at its role as the running dog (走狗) of the restoration-bureaucratic rulers; it is not genuinely asserting that it is a religion. At best, Confucianism belongs to a category of China's official ideology.

Readers will likely notice that I have persistently discussed two critical regions of the contemporary world—namely, Russia (俄罗斯) and Latin America (拉丁美洲)—exceedingly little, particularly the latter. The reason for this treatment is not because I believe these two regions lack research significance; I maintain that every locale is uniquely singular within the civilizational history of humanity, possessing irreplaceable value. Based on my fundamental judgments, I contend that these two regions ostensibly encountered severe difficulties during the transition from an **early modern society** (近世社会) to a **modern society** (现代社会). As I have persistently emphasized previously, China fundamentally never even touched the periphery of **early modern society**, let alone **modern society**. Therefore, if I were compelled to discuss these two regions, I could only rely upon materials of unverifiable accuracy alongside unassuredly rational inferences or even conjectures; if I wrote in granular detail, it might even mislead others.

Russia's own historical developmental trajectory and geographical position highly likely render it the critical tipping point (临界点) determining whether a region that experienced **feudalization** can autonomously modernize.

Exactly where Russia stagnated and regressed is ostensibly a controversial issue. Some might argue that Russia's **feudalization** itself was incomplete; upon the arrival of Western influence, **feudalization** rapidly ebbed, yet many early modern and modern factors had fundamentally not yet emerged. Based on this judgment, Russia should possess no essential distinction from Turkey, Iran, and India.

Others might contend that Russia unquestionably **feudalized** regardless, yet conspicuous divergence from Western Europe occurred during **early modern society** (*part of the reasons having been narrated previously*). Although capitalist factors (资本主义因素) emerged and Russia birthed a short-lived bourgeois regime (资产阶级政权) in 1917, the bureaucratic system subsequently achieved a comprehensive restoration under the cover of Marxism-Leninism (马克思列宁主义). Based on this judgment, Russia should be much closer to China. However, Russia's restoration-bureaucratic regime arrived a full epoch later than China's: China's restoration occurred during the transition from a **classical society** (古典社会) to a **feudal society** (封建社会), whereas Russia's restoration occurred during the transition from an **early modern society** to a **modern society**.

Ostensibly, both arguments possess validity, respectively reflecting partial realities of Russian history. The development of **feudalism** (封建主义) in Russia was inherently insufficient, naturally rendering the subsequent development of capitalism even more insufficient; consequently, the composition of the **restoration-bureaucratic state** here is inevitably vastly more complex than in China. Yet I would definitively assert that the degree of similarity between Russia and China unquestionably supersedes the degree of similarity between Russia and Turkey, Iran, and India; this is the most conventional judgment based on 20th-century history.

Observing their realistic manifestations, I still incline toward believing that the second explanation might be more quintessential. After all, the early modern and modern factors within Russian society are genuinely far too numerous relative to ordinary developing nations. Even the most vehement haters of Russians find it exceedingly difficult to deny that this nation's educational and academic

levels indeed exhibit the facade of a developed nation, as do its artistic and cultural creations. This is something that other nations which cannot even touch **early modern society** fundamentally cannot compare with. Although the Soviet Union (苏联) and PRC in the 20th century appeared highly similar, some of their manifestations exhibited colossal disparities (*which I shall not detail here*). This identically corroborates that Russia is a restoration-bureaucratic regime arriving substantially later than China's.

Latin America (拉丁美洲) is even more unfamiliar to Chinese people. Russia, at the very least, is the neighboring country with which our nation shares the longest land border, and our entanglement of love and hatred has persisted for four centuries. Latin America, relative to China, is situated quite literally on the exact opposite side of this ellipsoid we call Earth.

Today, when researching Latin America, one must definitively select two primary reference points: one being its former suzerains (宗主国), Spain and Portugal, and the other being the United States and Canada, identically located in the Americas. The disparities among various Latin American countries are by no means minor, but viewed as a whole, the development of this region can certainly not be considered poor; out of the 8 billion people globally, Latin America definitely does not rank in the bottom half.

I maintain that the exceptionality of Latin America lies in the fact that, among all colonial activities since the Age of Discovery (大航海时代), the scale in Latin America was colossal, its indigenous demographic composition and cultural beliefs were drastically replaced, and its suzerains were situated in the **early modern period** (近世) when they ruled here. Even when Latin America achieved independence, the Iberian Peninsula (伊比利亚半岛) had still not reached **modern society** (现代社会). This is utterly distinct from former colonial nations ruled by and subsequently independent from Britain, such as the United States, Canada, Australia, and New Zealand. When the Anglosphere nations universally achieved independence from Britain in various forms (*this even includes Ireland*), Britain as the suzerain had explicitly departed from **early modern society** (近世社会); it was already a bona fide capitalist country (资本主义国家).

The combination of "colony" plus "early modern state" patently engenders Latin America's exceptionality. These two concepts individually are phenomenally unfamiliar to Chinese people, and their juxtaposition is even rarer; therefore, I genuinely find it difficult to analyze the historical trajectory of Latin America.

However, there are certain glaringly obvious issues that anyone can definitively perceive. For instance, within the overarching European-dominated colonial system, colonies were explicitly relegated primarily to the position of exporting consumer goods and raw materials. How could any colonial empire possibly be more enthusiastic about the capitalist development of its colonies than that of its homeland? Not to mention that during their rule over the Americas, the domestic capitalist development of Spain and Portugal was itself exceedingly mediocre. Even after achieving political independence, it would require an immense amount of time under the most favorable circumstances for New World nations to alter their division of labor within the international market; even the United States spent nearly a century annihilating the plantation economy of its South.

During the transitional period from a **feudal society** (封建社会) to a capitalist society, capitalist factors suffered multifaceted suppressions, while the church and massive hacienda owners (大庄园主) persistently occupied a dominant position in politics for a prolonged duration. Consequently, it

is not surprising in the slightest that military dictatorships (军事独裁) and oligarchies (寡头统治) emerged within nominal republics. From my perspective as a Chinese individual, Latin America was at least sufficiently fortunate; after all, their suzerains, Spain and Portugal, were both nations that had genuinely undergone a complete **feudalization** (封建化) process. Therefore, although Latin America encountered immense difficulties during the **early modern period**, with the exception of Cuba, it fundamentally avoided being infected by the "Red Death" ("红死病") metastasizing from the Soviet Union, even though this peril genuinely appeared imminent during the latter half of the 20th century.

The manuscript previously mentioned that arid/semi-arid irrigation agricultural zones along major rivers have a significant inhibitory effect on **feudalization** (封建化), but I had not yet provided a convincing reason. Just a few days ago, while casually surfing the internet, I stumbled upon a clip from a Thai historical drama filmed a few years ago depicting the historical hegemony struggle between Thailand and Myanmar on the Indochina Peninsula [中南半岛], and suddenly realized that Thailand and Myanmar actually constitute a very excellent control group. The time when the Burmans migrated southward in scale from southwestern China to the Indochina Peninsula and established an independent state was significantly earlier than the Tai-Thai peoples; however, by the historical period when they came into close contact with the West, Thailand's degree of **feudalization** was obviously deeper than Myanmar's. This distinction highly likely stems from a major geographical fact: Myanmar's ruling center, the middle Irrawaddy River valley (i.e. the **Central Dry Zone**), receives an annual precipitation of merely 600 to 900 millimeters due to the rain shadow effect [雨影效应] and foehn effect [焚风效应] caused by the blockage of the Arakan Mountains, with extremely immense evaporation; furthermore, the temporal distribution of precipitation is very uneven under the influence of the monsoon. Therefore, it is actually a semi-arid region with monsoon deciduous forests and shrubs as its primary natural landscape. A few years ago, when a strong earthquake struck Upper Myanmar, I saw many images of Bagan on television, and it indeed gave the visual impression of a savanna [稀树草原]. Consequently, Myanmar historically relied heavily on irrigation agriculture in the semi-arid regions along the major river, forming a centralized core [集权核心] in the middle Irrawaddy River valley that, although not large in area, was very solid. In contrast, the annual precipitation in Thailand's core ruling zone is sufficient. The Thai people certainly also needed water conservancy projects, but the work they needed to do was the seasonal distribution of precipitation, rather than drawing water from fixed sources through irrigation systems under conditions of overall precipitation deficiency. Therefore, the water conservancy projects formed in Thailand primarily manifested as distributed, point-like water storage projects, which inherently would not exert a negative impact on the formation of the **feudal system** (封建制度).

Through the comparison between Myanmar and Thailand, we can clearly see why arid/semi-arid irrigation agricultural zones along major rivers suppress the process of **feudalization**. **First**, large-scale irrigation systems demand collective collaboration within large, contiguous tracts of land; if the land is fragmented into pieces, the irrigation system becomes difficult to maintain. Therefore, managing the entire irrigation district as a holistic entity possesses necessity in production. **Second**, large-scale irrigation districts are highly homogeneous in production and possess very weak economic division of labor; thus, the space for self-sufficiency is very limited, relying on external exchange. The **natural economy** (自然经济) is difficult to fully develop within irrigation districts, economically obstructing the emergence of the **feudal system**. **Third**, as previously mentioned in

the manuscript during the analysis of the Central Asian region, the reason why the **feudal system** possesses extremely high military defensive efficiency is not because of the superficial phenomenon of "having castles," but because it allows agricultural production and military defensive space to highly overlap. Therefore, for feudal rulers in Western Europe and Japan, they could conduct **siege warfare** (笼城作战) at a lower cost, as agriculture itself lacked a massive, easily destructible public node. In regions relying on irrigation agriculture, however, invaders merely need to destroy the irrigation system at a very low cost to rapidly weaken the defenders' agricultural potential. Therefore, rulers of irrigation agricultural zones need to defend irrigation facilities during wars, frequently forcing them to face decisive pitched battles. In summary, irrigation agriculture elevated the military costs of feudal fragmentation, thereby weakening the defensive advantages that the **feudal system** could provide, making it easier to maintain a higher degree of political centralization.

We can also explain this from an even simpler perspective. Assuming there is no irrigation system to channel river water to the arid fields, the productive value of these potentially fertile lands themselves is greatly discounted, or they might simply be wastelands. It is precisely because humans constructed the irrigation systems through labor that the irrigation district becomes a fertile expanse; that is to say, the value of the land is attached to the irrigation system, and land is no longer the final means of production [生产资料] determining productive capacity. Do not forget that, according to the classification of Marxist political economy, the irrigation system itself also belongs to the means of production. Therefore, although we cannot arbitrarily conclude that the irrigation system can become the **primary factor of production** (首位生产要素) in irrigation agricultural zones, we can relatively conservatively state that the ones who truly control production are not those who control a specific plot of land, but those who control the entire irrigation system. That is to say, in irrigation agricultural zones, the core means of production (*naturally also a factor of production*) determining social power relations has changed. The water conservancy projects relied upon by large-scale arid/semi-arid irrigation agricultural zones along major rivers are often massive in scale; unlike small-scale water storage projects that can be completed by village communities, they do not spatially overlap with the farmlands they serve in micro-geography. This weakened the dominant position of land in labor production, and subsequently in the construction of social relations, causing irrigation agricultural zones to be more prone to becoming the core of centralized rule, and difficult to form a **feudal system**.

Finally, I still wish to briefly discuss the issue of introducing commercial and trade factors into the underlying laws of human historical development.

It must be stated that the practice of considering commercial factors when researching the mutations of human history is virtually as ancient as the social sciences themselves. The problem lies in the fact that, in the past, people largely arrived at conclusions diametrically opposed to the facts—namely, the belief that commercial circulation could stimulate the host society to progress at an accelerated velocity, or even achieve leaps across developmental stages. However, when advanced commercial circulation emerges within a relatively backward region, we must not forget that the indigenous societal morphology is inherently backward to begin with. Commercial circulation does not act directly upon **productive forces** (生产力), nor does it even act directly upon the **relations of production** (生产关系); any elevating effect it might have on either is merely incidental.

For the participants in commercial activities, their primary concern is inevitably whether the commercial activity can be successfully completed; deliberately creating side issues on another country's turf is patently unwise. Therefore, for those pre-modern nations that ascended due to trade, the enhancement of state capacity by trade circulation is primary; in contrast, the enhancement of **productive forces** and **relations of production** is secondary. Commercial and trade factors augmented state capacity, and state capacity has never been exclusively utilized for benevolent purposes. In reality, it is not difficult for people to observe that the numerous **Trade-based pseudo-classical states** (贸易型伪古典国家) cited in this text universally confronted a common problem: any existing system possesses an inherent tendency toward self-preservation. Rather than being conducive to development, the augmentation of state capacity highly likely obstructed development instead.

In today's industrial society, major resource-exporting countries—especially energy-exporting countries—can be regarded as the equivalents of those trade-based nations in ancient societies that occupied vital communication arteries. Theoretically, they could acquire colossal foreign exchange reserves, provide robust welfare guarantees for their citizens, introduce elite talents, and execute investments of staggering magnitudes into fields such as education, culture, and science. But what about in reality? In Russia, Libya, Iraq, Iran, and Venezuela, exactly what transpired in the past, and exactly what is transpiring right now? Even for American allies such as Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates (UAE), and Qatar, their GDP per capita is indeed sufficiently high, but can they truly be mentioned in the same breath as the developed nations of Western Europe?

A backward societal morphology is fundamentally incapable of effectively utilizing the wealth in circulation to enhance **social efficiency** (社会效率); instead, it is far more accustomed to weaponizing this wealth to consolidate its own rule. This is precisely why we frequently observe that once **Trade-based pseudo-classical states** encounter drastic mutations in international trade routes, their former prosperity dissipates instantaneously like smoke; rather than achieving substantial societal progress, they plunge into protracted turbulence and stagnation.

31，对于本人一些判断的解释

我最后解释一下个人的一些判断，这些判断究竟是否合理还请读者自行甄别。

我为什么一直非常激烈地反对“民族性”这个提法，原因是作为一个理工科的学生，我不得不说它太不可证伪了，让人很难相信这是科学。如果我们把全世界每一个民族与其他民族不同的特征都叫作民族性，那么我们最后研究了什么呢，这不是等于说了一堆无用之话吗？只要有可能，就应该想办法认真研究当地社会的历史进程，而不是试着用一些完全无法定义的概念糊弄了事。他们不但会研究造成误导，而且也会令人类彼此之间的偏见加剧。

我为什么认为儒家学说不是一个宗教？我的想法很简单，那就是中国的历史经常太过特殊，以至于很难将儒家学说与某种类型的宗教相对应。首先读者如果按顺序读到现在，必然可以一眼看出复辟官僚时期的儒学就没办法说是一种宗教，它当然已经不是古典宗教，但更不可能是一种封建宗教。从事实上讲，复辟官僚国家最大的一个特点就是反宗教，朝廷不遗余力地削弱宗教在社会生活中的地位。其次，我们或许可以说两汉时期的经学是一种古典宗教，它确实也有古典宗教的一些特征。可是有哪个古典宗教如此一家独大地支持整个古典官僚体制呢？我认为汉代儒学与古典宗教最大的差异在于，古典宗教的核心目的是支持君主专制，而汉代儒学的核心目的是支持官僚制度。在汉代扮演支持君主专制的意识形态角色很大程度上属于阴阳五行这样的神秘主义思想。儒学虽然主动地（儒学家主动接纳）或者被动地（朝

廷强制推进)与神秘主义共融,但是毕竟有很大区别。在这种情况下,认为汉代儒学是一种古典宗教就缺少归类上的必要性。而在三到六世纪中国封建化最显著的时期,儒家学说的社会意识形态参与就很有限制了,宗教的生态位明显属于外来的佛教。而在汉代之前的儒家学说明显就和早期佛教一样更像一个秉持特定哲学观点的学术流派而不是什么宗教。既然这四个时期的儒家学说都与宗教具有差异,那就根本没有理由认为它是一种宗教。但是包括我在内的很多中国人在谈到儒学的时候,有的时候也会采取儒教的这个做法,但这其实是一种情绪性地讽刺它作为复辟官僚统治者的走狗,不是真的说它就是宗教。儒学充其量属于一种中国的官方意识形态。

读者应该会发现我对于当今世界的两个重要地区,即俄罗斯和拉丁美洲一直谈论得极少,尤其是后者。之所以这样处理,不是因为我认为这两个地区没有什么研究的重要性,我认为每一个地方在人类的文明史中都是独一无二的,具有不可替代的价值。从我的基本判断出发,我认为这两个地区应当是在近世向现代社会转型的过程中遇到了困难。就如同我之前一直强调的,中国毕竟完全没有摸到过近世社会的边缘,现代社会就更不用说了。因此如果让我谈论这两个地区那我也只能依托准确性难以保证的资料和未必合理的推理甚至猜想,写得细一点的话,甚至还可能误导别人。

俄罗斯本身的历史发展进程和地理位置很可能使它成为一个封建化发生地区能否自行现代化的临界点。关于俄国是从什么地方停滞并倒退显然是一个有争议的问题,有的人可能会认为俄国的封建化本身就不完全,当西方的影响到来之后封建化就迅速退潮了,但许多近现代因素根本还没有产生。基于这种判断,俄国应当和土耳其,伊朗,印度没有本质区别。也有的人可能会认为俄国无论如何确实封建化了,但是在近世社会与西欧出现了明显分歧(部分原因在之前已经叙述过),资本主义因素虽然出现,俄国在1917年也诞生过短命的资产阶级政权,可是随后官僚体制在马克思列宁主义的掩护下全面复辟。基于这种判断,俄国应该和中国更为接近,但是俄国的官僚复辟政权比中国晚了一个世代,中国是古典社会到封建社会过程中的复辟,俄国是近世社会到现代社会过程中的复辟。

显然这两种说法都有道理,它们各自反映了俄国历史的部分事实,俄国的封建主义发展就不充分,然后资本主义发展的自然更不充分,这里的复辟官僚国家成分必然比中国复杂得多。但是我肯定会认为俄国与中国的相似程度肯定大于俄国与土耳其,伊朗和印度的相似程度,这是基于20世纪历史最为常规的判断。就现实的表现来看,我还是认为第二种解释可能更本质一些,毕竟俄国社会的近代因素相对于一般的发展中国家还是有点多太多了。哪怕是最不喜欢的俄国人都很难否认这个国家的教育和学术水平的确有一个发达国家的样子,艺术和文化上的创造也是如此,这是其他连近世社会都摸不着的国家完全比不了的。20世纪苏联和新中国两国虽然看起来十分相似,但是有些表现差别非常大(此处就不细说),这也支持俄国是一个相对中国晚得多的复辟官僚政权。

拉丁美洲对于中国人来说就更陌生,俄罗斯好歹是与我国陆地边境线最长的邻国,爱恨情仇持续了四个世纪,拉丁美洲相对于中国干脆就在地球这个椭球体的正对面。现今人们研究拉丁美洲的时候肯定要选两个主要的参照物,一个是曾经的宗主国西班牙和葡萄牙,另一个是同在美洲的美国和加拿大。拉丁美洲不同国家差异并不小,但是从整体来看这个地区的发展肯定不能算差,全世界总共80亿人,拉丁美洲还轮不到后半段。我认为拉丁美洲的特殊性在于,在大航海以来的所有殖民活动中,拉丁美洲规模巨大,本地民族构成和文化信仰被大幅替换,且宗主国统治这里时处于近世,甚至拉美独立时伊比利亚半岛也没有到现代社会。这与美国,加拿大,澳大利亚和新西兰这样被英国统治并独立的前殖民地国家完全不一样。当英语国家普遍从英国中以各种形式独立出来时(这里甚至包括爱尔兰),英国作为宗主国显然离开了近世社会,它已经是一个如假包换的资本主义国家了。

殖民地加近世国家这个组合显然会导致拉丁美洲的特殊性,这两个词分别对中国人来说都极其陌生,出现到一起就更加稀有,因此我确实很难分析拉丁美洲的历史进程。不过一些显而易见的问题人们肯定都

能看出来，就比如殖民地在整个欧洲主导的殖民体系中显然主要被放在输出消费品的原材料的地位。怎么可能有个殖民帝国对于殖民地的资本主义发展比本土还要热情，更别说西班牙和葡萄牙在统治美洲期间自己国内资本主义发展就非常一般。即使在政治上获得独立，新大陆国家在国际市场中的分工要想改变在最有利的情况下也得花很多时间，连美国消灭南方的种植园经济都花了将近一个世纪。在封建社会向资本主义社会过渡的时期资本主义因素受到各种各样的打击，教会和大庄园主长期在政治上占有重要地位，名义上的共和国出现军事独裁和寡头统治就一点也不奇怪了。在我一个中国人看来，拉丁美洲至少足够幸运，毕竟他们的宗主国西班牙和葡萄牙都是真正经历过完整封建化进程的国家。因此拉丁美洲虽然在近世遇到了很大困难，但除了古巴以外总归没有被从苏联蔓延而来的“红死病”传染，哪怕在20世纪后半叶这种危险看起来确实存在。

文稿之前曾经提到，大河两岸的干旱/半干旱灌溉农业区对于封建化有显著的抑制作用，但是我还没有给出有说服力的原因。就在前几天，我偶然在互联网冲浪的时候看到了泰国前些年拍摄的讲述历史上泰国与缅甸在中南半岛争霸的电视剧片段，突然意识到，其实泰国和缅甸构成了一个非常绝佳的对照组。缅甸人成规模地从中国西南部南下至中南半岛并建立独立国家的时间显著地比傣泰人要早，然而等到与西方密切接触的历史时期，泰国的封建化程度明显要比缅甸更深。这种区别很有可能源于一个重大的地理事实，那就是缅甸的统治中心，也就是伊洛瓦底江中游的谷地（即中央干旱区），因为若开山脉阻挡形成的雨影效应和焚风效应，年降水量不过600至900毫米，蒸发量极其巨大，而且受季风影响降水的时间分布还极不均匀。因此那里实际上是一片半干旱的，以季风落叶林和灌木为主要自然景观的地区。前些年上缅甸发生强震的时候，我曾经在电视上看到过很多蒲甘的影像，的确给人一种稀树草原的观感。因此，缅甸在历史上就非常依赖于大河两岸半干旱地区的灌溉农业，在伊洛瓦底江中游谷地形成了一个虽然面积不大，但是非常坚实的集权核心。相比之下，泰国的统治核心区年降水量是充足的。泰国人当然也需要水利工程，但是他们需要做的工作是对降水进行季节性的分配，而不是在整体降水不足的情况下，通过灌溉系统从固定水源进行引水。因此，泰国形成的水利工程主要体现为分布式的，点状的储水工程，本身不会对封建制度形成产生负面影响。

通过缅甸和泰国的对比，我们能够明显看到大河两岸的干旱/半干旱灌溉农业区为什么会遏制封建化进程。首先，大型灌溉系统要求大块连续土地内共同协作，如果土地被分割的支离破碎，那么灌溉系统就难以维护。因此把整个灌区作为一个整体管理在生产上是具有必要性的。其次，大型灌溉区在生产上高度同质化，经济分工很弱，因此，自给自足的空间非常有限，依赖于外部交换。自然经济难以在灌溉区充分发展，从经济上阻碍了封建制度的产生。最后，正如文稿之前在对中亚地区的分析时提到的，封建制度之所以具有极高的军事防御效率，并不是因为“有城堡”这一表象，而是因为它能够让农业生产与军事防御空间高度重合。因此对于西欧和日本的封建统治者来说，他们可以以较低成本进行笼城作战，农业本身没有一个巨大的、容易摧毁的公共节点。而在依赖灌溉农业的地区，入侵者只需要以很低的成本摧毁灌溉体系，就能够迅速削弱防御者的农业潜力。因此灌溉农业区的统治者需要在战争中保卫灌溉设施，常常不得不面对主力会战。总之，灌溉农业提高了封建割据的军事成本，从而削弱了封建制度能够提供的防御优势，因此更容易维持较高程度的政治集中。

我们还可以从一个更简单的视角来进行解释。假设没有灌溉系统将大河的水引向干旱的田地，那么这些潜在的良田本身的生产价值是大打折扣的，甚至根本就是荒地。正是人类通过劳动修建了灌溉系统，灌区才会成为一片沃野，也就是说，土地的价值依附于灌溉系统，土地已经不再是决定生产能力的最终生产资料。不要忘记，根据马克思主义政治经济学的分类，灌溉系统本身也属于生产资料。因此，我们尽管不能武断地认为在灌溉农业区灌溉系统就能成为首位生产要素。但可以相对保守地讲，真正控制生产的人，并非是控制某块土地的人，而是控制整个灌溉系统的人。也就是说在灌溉农业区，决定社会权利

关系的那个核心生产资料（自然也是生产要素）发生了变化。大河两岸的大型干旱/半干旱灌溉农业区所依赖的水利工程往往规模庞大，不像那些村社就能够完成的小型储水工程一样在微观地理上与其服务的农田在空间上重合。这就削弱了土地在劳动生产中，进而是社会关系构建中的主导地位，导致灌溉农业区更容易成为成为一个集权统治的核心，而难以形成封建制度。

最后，我还是想再简单谈一下把商贸因素引入人类历史发展规律的问题。不得不说，在研究人类历史变迁的时候考虑商贸因素这件事几乎和社会科学本身同样古老。问题在于，人们在过去很大程度上得出了与事实相反的结论，即商业流通能够刺激所在社会以更快的速度进步，甚至实现发展阶段的跨越。然而，当发达的商业流通出现在一个相对落后地区时，我们不能忘记当地原本的社会形态就是落后的。商业流通不会直接作用于生产力，甚至不会直接作用于生产关系，它对于两者即使有提升作用也是附带的。对于商业活动的参与者而言，他们首先关注的一定是商业活动能否顺利完成，在别国的地盘上节外生枝并不明智。因此，对于前现代那些因为贸易兴起的国家而已，贸易流通对国家能力的提升是主要的，相比之下对生产力和生产关系的提升是次要的。商贸因素增强了国家能力，而国家能力从来都不是只做好事。实际上人们不难观察到本文中所举的许许多多的贸易型伪古典国家都面临一个问题，那就是任何已有的体制都有保全自身的倾向，国家能力的增强非但没有有益于发展，反而很可能阻碍发展。

在今天这个工业社会，重要的资源输出国尤其是能源输出国可以视为古代社会的那些占据交通要道的贸易型国家。理论上他们可以获得巨额外汇，他们可以为国民提供有力的福利保障，他们可以引进人才，他们可以往教育，文化，科学等领域进行数目惊人的投资。但是实际上呢？在俄罗斯、利比亚、伊拉克、伊朗和委内瑞拉，曾经发生过什么事，现在又正在发生什么事？即使是沙特、阿联酋和卡塔尔这些美国的盟国，他们的人均 GDP 确实够高，但是是否能够和西欧发达国家等量齐观呢？落后的社会形态是无法有效利用流通中的财富的以提高社会效率的，它反倒更习惯于用这些财富去巩固自身的统治。这也是我们为什么经常看到贸易型伪古典国家在遭遇国际贸易路线出现重大变化之后，原先的繁荣便立刻烟消云散，社会没有发生长足进步，而是陷入了持久的动荡和停滞。